technologies,' he declared, adding, 'The scale of cooperation is still small but the potential is great.' [112] According to Rajiv, the 'leitmotif' of non-alignment was 'the assertion of our right to unity, self-determination and independence' by virtue of which we have the right to 'freely pursue' our 'economic, social and cultural development without intimidation or hindrance'[113] by major powers.

During his five years as prime minister, Rajiv undertook forty-eight foreign trips. In his speeches and travels to fellow developing countries, which like India were former colonies, Rajiv would touch on topics which resonated: history and old civilization, colonialism, imperialism, and racialism. According to Healy, Rajiv 'links the Indian heritage of culture and freedom stymied under colonialism with the prospect of a new democracy on the march'.[114] He pursued closer ties with the United States than under Nehru or Indira alongside close identification with the world's developing countries.

Rajiv often emphasized India's key role in the global anti-imperialist struggle. 'Long before our independence, we were the first to raise our voice against racial discrimination in international organizations,' he once remarked. [115] On another occasion he said, 'When Gandhiji and Panditji fought for freedom, they did not think of freedom of India only. They were concerned about slavery and oppression wherever it was present in the world. Their aim was to get freedom for all these people. India got freedom and thereafter gradually all other countries got freedom one by one.'[116]

Under Rajiv, India sustained its position as a leading nation of the world without being among the wealthiest or the militarily most powerful. Rajiv focused on economic issues more than his predecessors, paving the way for even greater interest in India's growth by his successors. According to Raghavan, Rajiv understood that if India sought to grow and become a modern economy it needed to increase its imports and exports and obtain access to the latest technology. At the heart of Rajiv's championing of